

Navodaya: A Movement Empowering Rural Women Through Cooperation



Dr. M N Rajendra Kumar
Chairman of SCDCC Bank

Navodaya, a transformative self-help group (SHG) movement launched on January 29, 2000, has been a cornerstone of rural empowerment in Karnataka. Operating under the Navodaya Grama Vikas Charitable Trust, the initiative has touched the lives of over 1.8 lakh women across nine districts. Celebrating its 25th anniversary this year, the silver

jubilee event, **Rajatha Sambhrama 2025**, was held at Bangrakuloor in Mangaluru and attended by thousands of beneficiaries and dignitaries.

At the heart of Navodaya's success is Dr. M N Rajendra Kumar, Chairman of SCDCC Bank and the visionary behind the Trust. For over two decades, Dr. Kumar has been a steadfast advocate for the cooperative sector's power to drive social and economic change. His model, rooted in inclusive growth, has revolutionized the lives of rural women by offering them opportunities to become financially independent, confident, and self-reliant.

Dr. Kumar's efforts were lauded at the jubilee celebrations by Governor Thawar Chand Gehlot, who noted, "Navodaya is a shining example of what the cooperative model can achieve. Dr. Rajendra Kumar has brought a silent revolution to rural Karnataka, ensuring empowerment and dignity for thousands of women."

Women's empowerment has been central to Navodaya's mission. Through its network of SHGs, the movement has helped rural women access training, microcredit, and entrepreneurial opportunities. These women, once dependent on limited income sources, are now engaged in activities like tailoring, coir manufacturing, food

processing, and even rural tourism.

Each member is equipped with not just skills but also financial literacy. As a result, thousands of women have successfully managed their own small businesses, gained banking knowledge, and emerged as leaders in their communities.

Deputy Chief Minister D K Shivakumar, who was also present at the event, praised Dr. Kumar's leadership and the lasting impact of the SHG model. "What began as a modest effort is now a movement that has transformed over 15 lakh rural families. Navodaya proves that empowering women is the most effective way to strengthen communities and local economies," he said.

The jubilee celebrations also saw the release of a commemorative souvenir, **Navodaya Rajatha Sambhrama 2025**. The occasion was graced by several notable personalities including Minister Laxmi Hebbalkar, MP Nalin Kumar Kateel, Minister U T Khader, and Rajya Sabha MP Dr. D Veerendra Heggade. Udupi Pejawar Math Seer Vishwaprasanna Theertha Swamiji offered blessings, underlining the spiritual and cultural value of such social initiatives.

More than 3,000 SHG women entrepreneurs were honored during the event. Their stories of growth and resilience highlighted the transformational role Navodaya has played in their lives. Many have evolved from being homemakers to successful business owners, employing others and contributing to the local economy.

"Women of the coast and rural interiors have always shown strength—be it as fisherwomen or beedi workers. All they needed was a platform to rise. Navodaya gave them that," said Dr. Kumar.

In a gesture of national solidarity, Dr. Kumar also announced a ₹3 crore contribution to the Indian armed forces, reinforcing the Trust's broader commitment to public service.

Navodaya stands today as a beacon of cooperative success—a model that integrates financial inclusion, skill-building, and community development. As it enters its next chapter, the movement remains a testament to how grassroots efforts, when led with vision and compassion, can bring about real and lasting change.

